Who Is Responsible for Ireland's Road Deaths?

A briefing for members of the Oireachtas

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Hosted by Emer Currie TD

Wednesday 16 April 2026 — 12:45pm — AV Room

247

people killed on Irish roads in 2025

54 killed in 14 weeks of 2026. One person every 35 hours.

The worst decade trend in over a generation.

Ireland Is Not Failing Because People Don't Care

Ireland has a Road Safety Strategy.

It has 89 action items — 12 primary, 77 supporting.

It has dedicated officials working on this every day.

The RSA runs campaigns. TII invests in roads.

Minister Canney chairs a quarterly leadership group.

Everyone is doing their job.

And 247 people died.

So either everyone is doing their job badly —

which I don't believe —

or the system is designed in a way that produces

this outcome regardless of individual effort.

That's what I want to explore with you today.

A Story About "Impossible"

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Cynthia Carroll at Anglo American — Harvard Business School Case Study

In 2007, Carroll became CEO of one of the world's largest mining companies. Mining in South Africa killed workers every year.

The board wasn't negligent: they had safety programmes, they tracked metrics, they invested in training. Every initiative was best practice!

And yet workers kept dying.

Carroll didn't blame the board. She showed them that the system was designed to accept a certain level of death as normal. Once they saw it, they couldn't unsee it.

What Carroll Changed

She didn't add another safety programme.

She didn't launch an awareness campaign.

She changed who was accountable.

Mine managers became personally responsible for safety ***outcomes*** — not just safety ***processes***. She shut down operations when the standard wasn't met, even when it cost money.

> **Fatalities fell by over 60% within a year.**

Does This Sound Familiar?

ANGLO AMERICAN BEFORE CARROLL

"Deaths are inevitable"

"It's the nature of the industry"

"We're doing everything we can"

"Our programmes are best practice"

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DEPARTMENT OF TRANSPORT, 25 MARCH

"Deaths are inevitable"

"Vision Zero is naive"

"The strategy is working"

"Every action item is best practice"

These aren't careless people. This is a system describing itself accurately.

The System, Not the People

When the Department told me deaths are inevitable, they weren't being callous.

They were describing the system accurately.

In the current structure, deaths ARE inevitable — because nobody is designed to prevent them! The RSA runs campaigns. TII manages national roads. The Gardaí report to Justice. Local authorities answer to no one on road design. And Minister Canney coordinates quarterly.

That's not a moral failure. *It's an engineering one*.

Symptoms, Not Scandals

From a 90-minute meeting on 25 March — Keith Walsh (Asst Sec Gen) & Ian Kelleher

"Nobody is responsible for lost lives."	The system tracks activity, not outcomes. There is no consequence for missing the target.
"Vision Zero is naive."	The implementers don't believe in the target because they understand their own system. But a system that doesn't believe in its own goal will not achieve it.
Silence on how to measure progress.	No interim targets. No published metrics. No mechanism for knowing if the strategy is working.
"Factors outside our control."	When the problem changes and the structure doesn't adapt, the structure is the problem.

The Gap Between Activity and Outcome

89 action items. All best practice. All being implemented. Deaths rose 31%.

1.	**Actions insufficient?**	The problem grew faster than the strategy. But who triggers escalation? There is no mechanism.
2.	**Implementation too slow?**	14 cameras. NVDF Bill on 5th deadline. 30km/h not commenced. But who directs pace? Nobody can.
3.	**External factors?**	The Department's own explanation. But who redesigns the response when conditions change? Nobody is asked to.

In all three cases: someone needs to own the outcome, not just the activity.

THE ACCOUNTABILITY GAP

Who is responsible for Ireland's 2030 road safety target?

MINISTER OF STATE — SEÁN CANNEY

Chairs the Road Safety Leadership Group — meets quarterly

Cannot direct any of the bodies below

coordination only

ROAD SAFETY AUTHORITY (RSA)

HAS
Driver testing · Licensing
Awareness campaigns
(€18m/yr)

LACKS
Engineering capability
Power to compel councils
Infrastructure authority

Self-funded from test fees — conflict of interest.
Reform to split it was abandoned in Dec 2025.

DEPARTMENT OF TRANSPORT

HAS
Policy · Legislation
The strategy document

LACKS
Control of enforcement
Control of road design
Authority over agencies

"The Minister is responsible for the strategy being implemented." — Dept of Transport, 25 Mar

THE 2030 TARGET

Halve road deaths to 72

Held by: nobody

AN GARDA SÍOCHÁNA

HAS
Enforcement · Traffic corps
Crash scene attendance

LACKS
Road safety remit
Line to Transport Minister
Investigative mandate

Reports to Justice, not Transport.
Speeding detections down 43% since 2014.

TRANSPORT INFRASTRUCTURE IRELAND

HAS
National roads (5,500 km)
EU RISM audits · Design

LACKS
Remit for regional roads
Remit for local roads
Any role in 94% of network

Most deaths occur where TII has no authority.

31 LOCAL AUTHORITIES — managing 94% of the road network

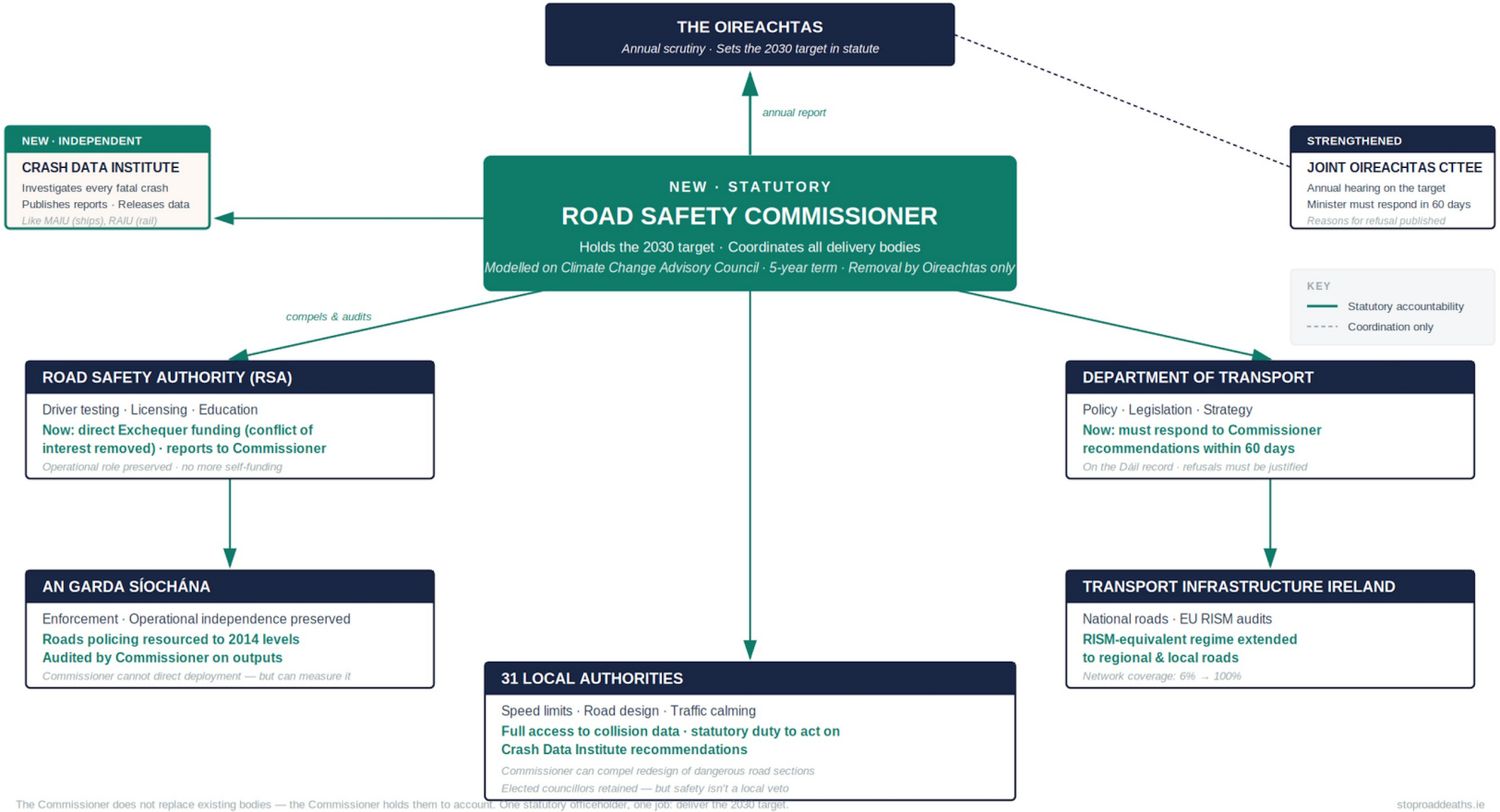
HAS
Speed limits · Road design · Traffic calming
Answer to elected councillors

LACKS
National safety inspection regime
Collision data since Nov 2023
Any body with power to compel action

Dashed lines indicate coordination without authority. Each actor holds a piece of the system; none holds the outcome.

A SYSTEM DESIGNED FOR ZERO

What the structure looks like when someone owns the outcome



The Commissioner does not replace existing bodies — the Commissioner holds them to account. One statutory officeholder, one job: deliver the 2030 target.

Countries That Redesigned the System

They didn't care more; they changed who was accountable.

NORWAY	**16**	per million	200-measure plan (Mar 2026). Default 30km/h. Director reports to Parliament.
SWEDEN	**22**	per million	Vision Zero since 1997. Split the agency. Annual parliamentary reporting.
FINLAND	**25**	per million	1,164 cameras. Investigates every fatal crash. Published findings.
UK	**24**	per million	New strategy Jan 2026. 65% reduction target. Investigation branch.
IRELAND	**33**	per million	14 cameras. No investigation. Commissioner asked 8 times — never answered.

What the Parliamentary Record Shows

35+ PQs tabled. The system's own answers reveal the design flaw.

Commissioner?	"High-profile ambassadors"	8 times across 2 jurisdictions
Camera deployment?	14 cameras total	Finland: 1,164. Sweden: 2,487
Collision data?	Not shared since Nov 2023	NVDF Bill: 5th deadline
Road policing?	"Download spreadsheet"	Corps −17%. Detections −43%
Total spending?	Cannot be answered as one PQ	Split across 3 Ministers
Cross-border targets?	None set	1 NSMC meeting in 14 months

Every structural question receives a communications answer. The system deflects, not solves.

Can Zero Be Real?

Helsinki: zero traffic deaths for 12 months.

Oslo: zero pedestrian and cyclist deaths for a full year.

Anglo American: fatalities fell 62% when managers owned outcomes, not processes.

Aviation: independently investigates every incident. System learns. Deaths near zero.

Irish rail: RAIU investigates. Published reports. Recommendations tracked.

Irish roads: no equivalent. 247 deaths. No investigation. No published findings.

A Question, Not a Demand

You don't need to agree with me today.

I'm asking you to consider one question:

Is the current system designed to produce the outcome we want?

If the answer is no — and the Department's own answers suggest it is — then the question becomes:

What would a system designed for zero look like?

Five Conditions for a System Designed for Zero

1	**ROAD SAFETY COMMISSIONER**	Someone who owns the outcome. Reports to the Oireachtas. Holds the 2030 target.
2	**AUTOMATED SPEED CAMERAS**	Enforcement that works 24/7 without depending on Garda resources. Revenue-positive.
3	**BLACK SPOT REDESIGN**	Fix the roads where people keep dying. Published timelines. Mandatory post-crash review.
4	**RESTORE ENFORCEMENT**	Road policing back to 2014 levels within two years. Visible, consistent, resourced.
5	**CRASH DATA TO ENGINEERS**	NVDF Bill enacted this year. Accurate data. Engineers can see where people are dying.

I asked the Department of Transport who is responsible when someone dies on an Irish road.

They told me:

Nobody.

That's not an accusation. It's a diagnosis.

The system is designed this way. It can be redesigned.

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APPENDIX · THE DATA

Ireland vs. European peers: what the numbers show

OUTCOMES & GOVERNANCE

COUNTRY	DEATHS/MILLION (2024)	TREND 2019–2024	VISION ZERO ADOPTED	LEAD AGENCY	INDEPENDENT CRASH INVESTIGATION
Norway	16	~35%+ decline	2002	NPRA + Vegtilsynet (auditor)	Yes
Sweden	~20	Steady decline	1997	Trafikverket	Yes
Finland	~30	~15%	Early 2000s	Traficom + OTI (investigator)	Yes — OTI, est. 1960s
Netherlands	~32	Decline	1997	SWOV + Rijkswaterstaat	Yes
IRELAND	~33	+32% (to 2023)	Stated in strategy	No lead agency	No — none exists

ENFORCEMENT — CAMERAS & FINES

COUNTRY	FIXED CAMERA POINTS	FINE SYSTEM
Finland	1,164	Income-based (fines can exceed €100,000)
Sweden	2,487	Day-fine system
Norway	Extensive (avg-speed focus)	Income-scaled (starts €700+)
IRELAND	~14 (5 avg-speed + 9 static)	Flat €80 regardless of income

FOR CONTEXT

2023: A Finnish multimillionaire was fined €121,000 for driving 30 km/h over the limit.
In Ireland, the same offence carries a flat fine of €80. It is a toll, not a deterrent.

IRELAND'S ENFORCEMENT COLLAPSE

SPEEDING DETECTIONS

−43%

217,475 (2014)
→ ~124,000 (2024)

GARDA TRAFFIC CORPS

−17%

804 (2013)
→ 664 (2023)

ROAD DEATHS SAME PERIOD

+31%

Deaths rose for
five consecutive years

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS — AUTOMATED CAMERAS WORK

META-ANALYSIS

18–32%

reduction in fatal crashes from
automated camera enforcement

UK — M1 SECTION 71

−63%

fatal & serious crashes after
average-speed cameras installed

HELSINKI

365 days

zero traffic deaths
(July 2024 – July 2025)

NORWAY — 14 SECTIONS

−12%

average speed reduction; lowest
road mortality rate in Europe

THE ECONOMIC CASE

COST OF ONE ROAD DEATH

€2.8m

RSA estimate per fatality
(EU standard: €3.5–4m)

CAMERA NETWORKS

Net revenue-positive

Fine income exceeds operating cost.
Deployment pays for itself.

SOURCES

ETSC PIN Reports (2024, 2025) · Finnish Police · Swedish Transport Administration · An Garda Síochána · RSA Annual Reports · DfT PQ answers (Ward, Buckley, Cairns, Heneghan 2026) · Indecon RSA Review (2024)
Ireland fixed camera count from Minister Canney's PQ reply, 18 March 2026 · Garda Traffic Corps figures from Dept of Justice PQ data · Helsinki figure: City of Helsinki road safety statistics (2025)